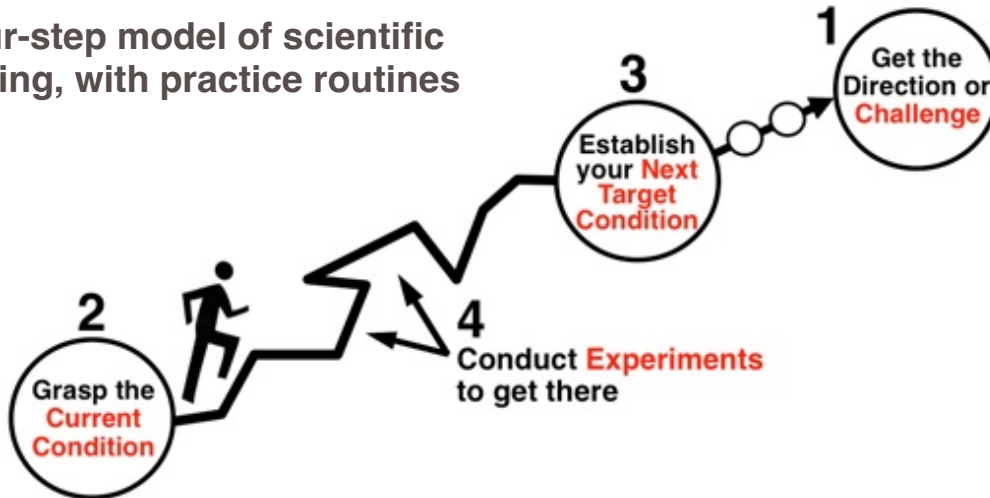


TOYOTA KATA	1. Improvement Kata	2. Coaching Kata	3. Kata Creates Culture	4. Getting Started	5. The TK Starter Kata
	Supporting Materials	The Improvement Kata Exercise	Value Stream Mapping	Extras	Challenge

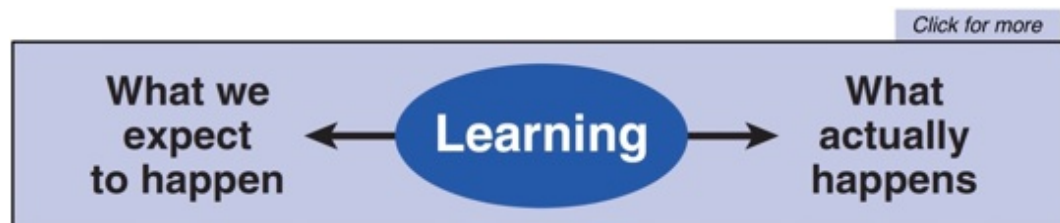
The Improvement Kata + Starter Kata

A four-step model of scientific thinking, with practice routines



Today's prescriptions probably won't fit tomorrow's problems, and the path to a challenging goal can't be determined in advance anyway. Your best bet is to practice a universal means of developing your own solutions (a "meta skill" for any situation). That's what you learn by practicing the Improvement Kata.

When conditions are complex and dynamic, scientific thinking may be the best approach we have for navigating. Scientific thinking means knowing that any idea should be tested. It means learning to compare what you think (theory) with what actually happens (evidence), and adjusting based on what you discover from the difference. It's a way of thinking that makes us better at reaching difficult goals through unpredictable territory.



However, scientific thinking is not our natural, default mode. What normally happens is that our brain quickly and unconsciously jumps to conclusions. Scientific thinking is not difficult, it's just not our habit.



Adults learn scientific thinking through practice. There are simple "Starter Kata" practice

routines for each step of the Improvement Kata, and for coaching, which speed up your learning and make it easier to scale in teams and organizations. The Improvement Kata models a pattern of practical, everyday scientific thinking, and the Starter Kata are what you practice to develop the thinking.

Instructions for the Starter Kata are in the [Toyota Kata Practice Guide](#).



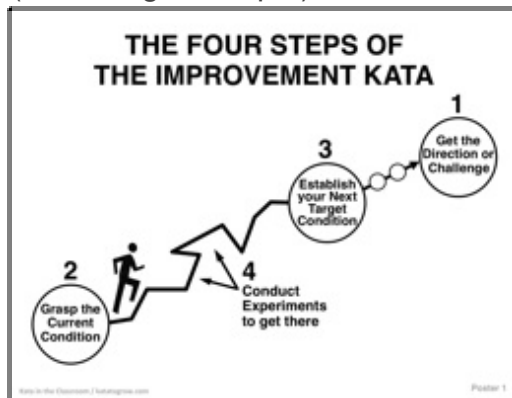
You can start practicing one Starter Kata today:

- ★ *You're a manager who needs to run a meeting and are wondering how to best do that.*
- ★ *You would like to add useful (and marketable) skills to your personal portfolio.*
- ★ *You're an educator who wants to help students practice critical-thinking STEM skills.*
- ★ *You want to empower your teams.*
- ★ *You're curious about the Improvement Kata.*
- ★ *You want to develop the necessary mindset to use Lean techniques.*
- ★ *Your new business is growing and you need a management system.*

Take a first mini step today. Print out the **Improvement Kata poster** and get a few **five question cards**. Read through the questions on the card, in the order shown, with your team, in meetings, etc. You'll be adding scientific-thinking focus and flow to any meeting.

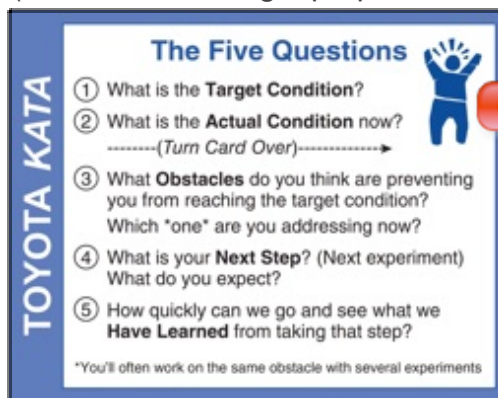
Improvement Kata Poster

(click image for a pdf)



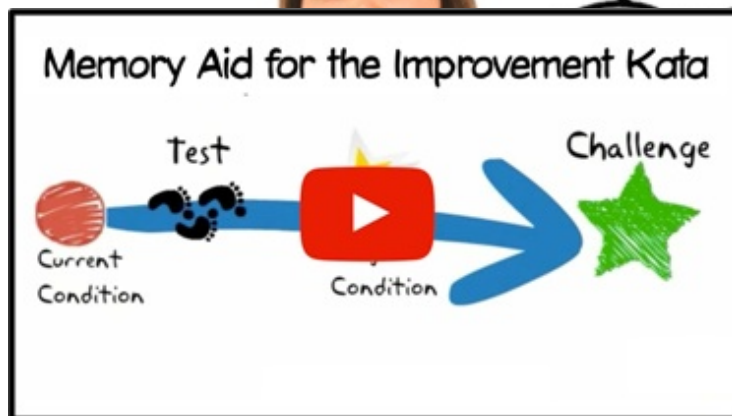
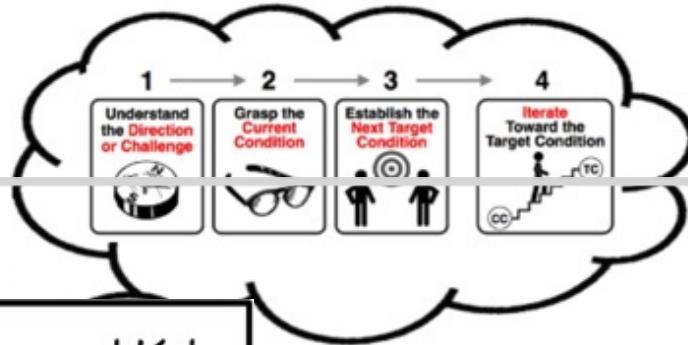
Five-Question Card

(click the card, or get preprinted cards [here](#))



Introduction to the Improvement Kata

Mike Rother
January 2011



Learning to Learn

Knowledge assets are not just the knowledge already created, such as know-how, patents, technologies, or brands, but also include the knowledge to create knowledge, such as the organizational capability to innovate. Although current views on knowledge assets tend to focus on the former because they are easier to measure and deal with, it is the latter that need more attention because they are the source of new knowledge to be created, and therefore a source of the future value of the firm.

One of the most important knowledge assets for a firm is a firm-specific **kata** (roughly, "pattern" or "Way of doing things") of dialogues and practices. Nelson and Winter (1982) emphasize the importance of routines for the firm's evolutionary process. Here, we focus on "creative routines" of **kata**, which make knowledge creation possible by fostering creativity and preserving efficiency.

Excerpt from: Ichijo, Kazuo and Nonaka, Ikujiro, *Knowledge Creation and Management: New Challenges for Managers*, Oxford University Press, 2006, page 25.



*"Go where there is no path
and leave a trail." ~ Emerson*

*"If you go through the Improvement Kata process
you'll get to where you need to get to. And the
more times you do it the better you will get at it."*

~ Jim Huntzinger, President, Lean Frontiers



Click to read about
the TK research
and findings

Next: 2. The Coaching Kata >>

